
The BorGal project. What's next?

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Abstract

This paper outlines the current development of the *Borelli Galaxy* project. Based at Sapienza University of Rome, BorGal focuses on the mathematician G.A. Borelli (1608–1679), a disciple of Galileo and an ideologue of the Messina Revolt of 1676. The project aims to produce a unified electronic catalogue of Borelli's correspondence and to use his letters as a source for mapping and analysing his overlapping intellectual, social, and political networks.

BorGal adopts a relational perspective, supported by digital tools, to test the alleged convergence of philosophical and political dissent in Borelli's life-and, more broadly, in Counter-Reformation Italy-through the analytical category of "faction" (Lemercier, 2015; Gregory, 2020). Project data are currently hosted in the Nodegoat web environment and are structured around two main entities: *Letters* and *Persons*. Epistolary exchanges provide evidence not only of the relationships between Borelli and his correspondents, but also of wider shared connections.

Letters, however, are not the sole source of relational evidence. Other acts and circumstances-such as co-editing or sponsoring a book, belonging to academies or learned circles, or participating in public events-also contributed to the construction and disclosure of relationships. These elements are recorded in BorGal as attributes or related objects, providing contextual information that enriches and qualifies the network (van Vugt, 2017).

At present, the correspondence metadata have been completed (669 letters), and senders, recipients, and individuals mentioned in the letters have been identified (667 persons). On this basis, the paper addresses a set of open methodological issues: the reliability of the reconstructed network in light of gaps in the epistolary record; the extent to which relational searches should be expanded to capture less visible connections (such as relatives, patrons, or women); the opportunity and limits of applying algorithmic analysis to a relatively small and non-big data corpus; and the visualization of network transformations over time and space. The paper concludes by outlining possible directions for the next phase of the project.

References:

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Keywords: Epistolary networks, History of science, Political factions, Scientific dissent, Relational databases, Nodegoat, Multi, layered networks